

3. Documentary Evidence/History

3.1. History

This history was written by Meg Quinlisk. The 2005 CMP contains a detailed account of the development of the estate, which can be found at Appendix 1

The Waverley War Memorial Hospital is the result of the philanthropic benefaction of the Edina estate, made by the descendants of Ebenezer Vickery (1827-1906), who was a successful and influential Sydney merchant during the second half of the 19th century.

Vickery purchased the majority of the estate at Waverley in 1859. The property already contained a house known as Rockhampton, built about 1853. In 1874 and 1875, Vickery purchased two additional allotments of land contiguous with the Edina estate, thus returning the property to its originally-granted form of 1840: an 8-acre portion bounded by Birrell Street, Church Street, Carrington Road and Bronte Road. The mansion at the heart of the estate was constructed in 1884 by the builder William Leggoe of Paddington¹, probably to the design of Thomas Rowe. Rowe (1829-1899) was one of the most prominent architects in New South Wales in the later 19th century. He was a Methodist, and his offices were in Vickery's Chambers on Pitt Street. Rowe had previously designed business premises for Vickery, as well as a number of Methodist churches which were financed by Vickery.

Other buildings on the estate completed by 1888 include the stables and coach house and a gate lodge. A private drive extended off Birrell Street and passed between a semi-detached pair of villas known as Wytchazel and Banksia (built c.1882 to accommodate Vickery's sons²), and the house known as Ellerslie (housing a Vickery son-in-law; built c.1882; possibly contains remnants of the 1853 house Rockhampton). Photographs from this period show that the estate was planned along the lines of the picturesque aesthetic: the principle houses sat on grassed terraces raised above a formal lawn and pleasure garden laid out with paths and decorated with statuary and a pond. Thick plantings of trees and bushes created a backdrop 'wilderness' setting in views of the house obtained as a visitor approached via the formal driveway from the northwestern corner of the estate (at the intersection of Birrell Street and Bronte Road).

¹ 'Advertising', *Sydney Morning Herald*, 17 January 1884, p. 13.

² Thomas Rowe called for tenders for the erection of two semi-detached villas at Waverley in November 1881; 'Advertising', *Sydney Morning Herald* 24 November 1881, p. 11.